The Second World War

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THE Grand Alliance

Winston S. Churchill

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PREFACE

THIS VOLUME, like the others, claims only to be a contribution to the history of the Second World War. The tale is told from the standpoint of the British Prime Minister, with special responsibility as Minister of Defence for military affairs. As these came directly to some extent into my hands, British operations are narrated in their scope and in some detail. At the same time it would be impossible to describe the struggles of our Allies except as a background. To do full justice these must be left to their own historians, or to later and more general British accounts. While recognising the impossibility of preserving proportion, I have tried to place our own story in its true setting.

The main thread is again the series of my directives, telegrams, and minutes upon the daily conduct of the war and of British affairs. These are all original documents composed by me as events unfolded. They therefore constitute a more authentic record and give, I believe, a better impression of what happened and how it seemed at the time than any account which I could write now that the course of events is known. Although they contain expressions of opinion and forecasts which did not come true, it is by them as a whole that I wish my own share in the conflict to be judged. Only in this way can the reader understand the actual problems we had to face as defined by the knowledge then in our possession.

Space would not allow, nor indeed in many cases have I the right, to print the replies, which very often took the form of lengthy departmental memoranda. I have therefore been careful to avoid, so far as I can, throwing blame on individuals. Where possible I have endeavoured to give a summary of replies to telegrams. In the main however the documents which are printed tell the tale.

We are again dealing with war on the giant scale, and the battle on the Russian front involved as many divisions on both sides as were engaged in the Battle of France. At every point along a far longer front the great masses engaged, with slaughter incomparable to anything which occurred elsewhere during the war. I cannot attempt to do more than refer to the struggle between the German and the Russian Armies as the background of the actions of Britain and the Western Allies. The Russian epic of 1941 and 1942 deserves a detailed and dispassionate study and record in the English language. Even though no facilities for foreigners to narrate the Russian agony and glory might be accorded, the effort should be made. Nor should this impulse be chilled by the fact that the Soviet Government have already claimed all the honour for themselves.

Hitler's invasion of Russia brought to an end the period of almost exactly a year during which Great Britain and her Empire stood alone, undismayed, and growing continually in strength. Six months later the United States, violently assaulted by Japan, became our ally for all purposes. The ground for our united action had been prepared beforehand by my correspondence with President Roosevelt, and it was possible to forecast not only the form of our operations but also their sequence. The effective combination of the whole English-speaking world in the waging of war and the creation of the Grand Alliance form the conclusion to this part of my account.

WINSTON S. CHURCHILL

CHARTWELL
January 1, 1950

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Pearl Harbour!

Sunday, December 7, at Chequers — My American Guests — Nine O'Clock News on the Wireless — Japan Attacks the United States — I Call the President — My Message to Mr. de Valera — I Rejoice — The Certainty of Victory — I Decide to Go to Washington — Letter to the King — The President's Anxiety About the Return Voyage — British Declaration of War on Japan — My Letter to the Japanese Ambassador — Parliament Approves the Declaration of War Unanimously — Mr. Duff Cooper's Appointment — Magnitude of the American Disaster — The Stroke in the Philippines — Hitler's Astonishment — We Discuss the Employment of the "Prince of Wales" and the "Repulse" — Admiral Phillips's Adventurous Plan — Air Support Lacking — The Admiral Withdraws — Tries Again — The Deadly Japanese Attack — "All Sunk Beneath the Wave" — The Morning Brings Fearful News — My Preparations for Departure — My Statement to the House, December 12 — Mr. Eden Starts on His Mission to Moscow — I Tell Him Some News.

IT WAS SUNDAY EVENING, December 7, 1941. Winant and Averell Harriman were alone with me at the table at Chequers. I turned on my small wireless set shortly after the nine o'clock news had started. There were a number of items about the fighting on the Russian front and on the British front in Libya, at the end of which some few sentences were spoken regarding an attack by the Japanese on American shipping at Hawaii, and also Japanese attacks on British vessels in the Dutch East Indies. There followed a statement that after

the news Mr. Somebody would make a commentary, and that the Brains Trust programme would then begin, or something like this. I did not personally sustain any direct impression, but Averell said there was something about the Japanese attacking the Americans, and, in spite of being tired and resting, we all sat up. By now the butler, Sawyers, who had heard what had passed, came into the room, saying, "It's quite true. We heard it ourselves outside. The Japanese have attacked the Americans." There was a silence. At the Mansion House luncheon on November 11 I had said that if Japan attacked the United States a British declaration of war would follow "within the hour." I got up from the table and walked through the hall to the office, which was always at work. I asked for a call to the President. The Ambassador followed me out, and, imagining I was about to take some irrevocable step, said, "Don't you think you'd better get confirmation first?"

In two or three minutes Mr. Roosevelt came through. "Mr. President, what's this about Japan?" "It's quite true," he replied. "They have attacked us at Pearl Harbour. We are all in the same boat now." I put Winant onto the line and some interchanges took place, the Ambassador at first saying, "Good," "Good" — and then, apparently graver, "Ah!" I got on again and said, "This certainly simplifies things. God be with you," or words to that effect. We then went back into the hall and tried to adjust our thoughts to the supreme world event which had occurred, which was of so startling a nature as to make even those who were near the centre gasp. My two American friends took the shock with admirable fortitude. We had no idea that any serious losses had been inflicted on the United States Navy. They did not wail or lament that their country was at war. They wasted no words in reproach or sorrow. In fact, one might almost have thought they had been delivered from a long pain.

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Parliament would not have met till Tuesday, and the

Members were scattered about the Island, with all the existing difficulties of communication. I set the office to work to ring up the Speaker, the Whips, and others concerned, to call both Houses together next day. I rang the Foreign Office to prepare to implement without a moment's delay a declaration of war upon Japan, about which there were some formalities, in time for the meeting of the House, and to make sure all members of the War Cabinet were called up and informed, and also the Chiefs of Staff and the Service Ministers, who, I rightly assumed, had had the news.

This done, my thought turned at once to what has always lain near my heart. To Mr. de Valera I sent the following message:

8 Dec. 41

Now is your chance. Now or never! A nation once again! I will meet you wherever you wish.

I thought also of struggling China, and telegraphed to Chiang Kai-shek:

8 Dec. 41

The British Empire and United States have been attacked by Japan. Always we have been friends: now we face a common enemy.

We also sent the following:

Prime Minister to Mr. Harry Hopkins 8 Dec. 41

Thinking of you much at this historic moment. — WINSTON, AVERELL.

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No American will think it wrong of me if I proclaim that to have the United States at our side was to me the greatest joy. I could not foretell the course of events. I do not pretend to have measured accurately the martial might of Japan, but now at this very moment I knew the United States was in the war, up to the neck and in to the death. So we had won after all! Yes, after Dunkirk; after the fall of France; after the horrible

episode of Oran; after the threat of invasion, when, apart from the Air and the Navy, we were an almost unarmed people; after the deadly struggle of the U-boat war — the first Battle of the Atlantic, gained by a hand's-breadth; after seventeen months of lonely fighting and nineteen months of my responsibility in dire stress, we had won the war. England would live; Britain would live; the Commonwealth of Nations and the Empire would live. How long the war would last or in what fashion it would end, no man could tell, nor did I at this moment care. Once again in our long Island history we should emerge, however mauled or mutilated, safe and victorious. We should not be wiped out. Our history would not come to an end. We might not even have to die as individuals. Hitler's fate was sealed. Mussolini's fate was sealed. As for the Japanese, they would be ground to powder. All the rest was merely the proper application of overwhelming force. The British Empire, the Soviet Union, and now the United States, bound together with every scrap of their life and strength, were, according to my lights, twice or even thrice the force of their antagonists. No doubt it would take a long time. I expected terrible forfeits in the East; but all this would be merely a passing phase. United we could subdue everybody else in the world. Many disasters, immeasurable cost and tribulation lay ahead, but there was no more doubt about the end.

Silly people — and there were many, not only in enemy countries — might discount the force of the United States. Some said they were soft, others that they would never be united. They would fool around at a distance. They would never come to grips. They would never stand blood-letting. Their democracy and system of recurrent elections would paralyze their war effort. They would be just a vague blur on the horizon to friend or foe. Now we should see the weakness of this numerous but remote, wealthy, and talkative people. But I had studied the American Civil War, fought out to the last desperate inch. American blood flowed in my veins. I thought of a remark which Edward Grey had made to me

more than thirty years before — that the United States is like "a gigantic boiler. Once the fire is lighted under it there is no limit to the power it can generate." Being saturated and satiated with emotion and sensation, I went to bed and slept the sleep of the saved and thankful.

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As soon as I woke I decided to go over at once to see President Roosevelt. I put the matter to the Cabinet when we met at noon. On obtaining their approval I wrote to the King.

December 8, 1941

Sir,

I have formed the conviction that it is my duty to visit Washington without delay, provided such a course is agreeable to President Roosevelt, as I have little doubt it will be. The whole plan of the Anglo-American defence and attack has to be concerted in the light of reality. We have also to be careful that our share of munitions and other aid which we are receiving from the United States does not suffer more than is, I fear, inevitable. The fact that Mr. Eden will be in Moscow while I am at Washington will make the settlement of large-scale problems between the three great Allies easier.

These reasons were accepted by my colleagues in the Cabinet unanimously today, and I therefore ask Your Majesty's permission to leave the country. I should propose to start quite soon, in a warship, and to be absent altogether for about three weeks. I shall take with me a staff on the same scale as I took to the Atlantic meeting.

During my absence the Lord Privy Seal will act for me, assisted by the Lord President of the Council, the Chancellor of the Exchequer, and other members of the War Cabinet. I would propose that during this period the three Service Ministers should temporarily sit with the War Cabinet. While I am away the Foreign Office will report to the Lord President, and the Defence Committee to the Lord Privy Seal. I shall of course be constantly in touch by wireless with all that goes on, and can give decisions whenever necessary. I should propose to take with me the First Sea Lord and the Chief of the Air Staff, as the concert of all our arrangements with the Americans on a high level is all-important.

I hope I may receive Your Majesty's approval of this course. I am of course keeping my intention secret.

With my humble duty, I remain

Your Majesty's most devoted, faithful servant and subject,

WINSTON S. CHURCHILL

PS. I am expecting that Germany and Italy will both declare war on the United States, as they have bound themselves by treaty to do so. I shall defer proposing my visit to the President until this situation is more clear.

The King gave his assent.

Former Naval Person to President Roosevelt 9 Dec. 41

I am grateful for your telegram of December 8. Now that we are, as you say, "in the same boat," would it not be wise for us to have another conference? We could review the whole war plan in the light of reality and new facts, as well as the problems of production and distribution. I feel that all these matters, some of which are causing me concern, can best be settled on the highest executive level. It would also be a very great pleasure to me to meet you again, and the sooner the better.

2. I could, if desired, start from here in a day or two, and come by warship to Baltimore or Annapolis. Voyage would take about eight days, and I would arrange to stay a week, so that everything important could be settled between us. I would bring Pound, Portal, Dill, and Beaverbrook, with necessary staffs.

3. Please let me know at earliest what you feel about this.

The President feared that the return journey would be dangerous. I reassured him.

Former Naval Person to President Roosevelt 10 Dec. 41

We do not think there is any serious danger about the return journey. There is however great danger in our not having a full discussion on the highest level about the extreme gravity of the naval position, as well as upon all the production and allocation issues involved. I am quite ready to meet you at Bermuda, or to fly from Bermuda to Washington. I feel it would be disastrous to wait for another month before we settled common action in face of new adverse situation, particularly in Pacific. I had hoped to start tomorrow night, but will postpone my sailing till I have

received rendezvous from you. I never felt so sure about the final victory, but only concerted action will achieve it. Kindest regards.

The next day I heard again from the President. He said that he was delighted that I was coming to stay at the White House. He felt that he could not leave the country himself. Mobilisation was taking place, and the naval position in the Pacific was uncertain. He felt sure that we could work out all the difficulties connected with production and supply. He emphasised again the personal risk of my journey, which he thought should be carefully considered.

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The War Cabinet authorised the immediate declaration of war upon Japan, for which all formal arrangements had been made. As Eden had already started on his journey to Moscow and I was in charge of the Foreign Office, I sent the following letter to the Japanese Ambassador:

Foreign Office, December 8

Sir,

On the evening of December 7th His Majesty's Government in the United Kingdom learned that Japanese forces without previous warning either in the form of a declaration of war or of an ultimatum with a conditional declaration of war had attempted a landing on the coast of Malaya and bombed Singapore and Hong Kong.

In view of these wanton acts of unprovoked aggression committed in flagrant violation of International Law and particularly of Article 1 of the Third Hague Convention relative to the opening of hostilities, to which both Japan and the United Kingdom are parties, His Majesty's Ambassador at Tokyo has been instructed to inform the Imperial Japanese Government in the name of His Majesty's Government in the United Kingdom that a state of war exists between our two countries.

I have the honour to be, with high consideration,

Sir,

Your obedient servant,

WINSTON S. CHURCHILL

Some people did not like this ceremonial style. But after all when you have to kill a man it costs nothing to be polite.

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Parliament met at 3 P.M., and in spite of the shortness of notice the House was full. Under the British Constitution the Crown declares war on the advice of Ministers, and Parliament is confronted with the fact. We were therefore able to be better than our word to the United States, and actually declared war upon Japan before Congress could act. The Royal Netherlands Government had also made their declaration. In my speech I said:

Mr. Churchill's Speech to Parliament, December 8, 1941

It is of the highest importance that there should be no under-rating of the gravity of the new dangers we have to meet, either here or in the United States. The enemy has attacked with an audacity which may spring from recklessness, but which may also spring from a conviction of strength. The ordeal to which the English-speaking world and our heroic Russian Allies are being exposed will certainly be hard, especially at the outset, and will probably be long, yet, when we look around us over the sombre panorama of the world, we have no reason to doubt the justice of our cause or that our strength and will-power will be sufficient to sustain it.

We have at least four-fifths of the population of the globe upon our side. We are responsible for their safety and for their future. In the past we have had a light which flickered, in the present we have a light which flames, and in the future there will be a light which shines over all the land and sea.

Both Houses voted unanimously in favour of the decision.

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I thought it necessary at this juncture that Mr. Duff Cooper, who had returned to Singapore, should be at once appointed Resident Minister for Far Eastern Affairs.

Prime Minister to Mr. Duff Cooper 9 Dec. 41

You are appointed Resident Cabinet Minister at Singapore for

Far Eastern affairs. You will serve under, and report directly to, the War Cabinet, through its Secretary. You are authorised to form a War Council, reporting first its composition and the geographical sphere it will cover. This will presumably coincide with the geographical sphere of the military Commander-in-Chief. Your principal task will be to assist the successful conduct of operations in the Far East (*a*) by relieving the Commanders-in-Chief as far as possible of those extraneous responsibilities with which they have hitherto been burdened; and (*b*) by giving them broad political guidance.

2. Your functions will also include the settlement of emergency matters on the spot, where time does not permit of reference home. You will develop a local clearing-house for prompt settlement of minor routine matters which would otherwise have to be referred to separate departments here. On all matters on which you require special guidance you will, provided there is time, refer the matter home. You will in any case report constantly to His Majesty's Government.

3. When Captain Oliver Lyttelton was appointed Minister of State at Cairo it was laid down that this did not affect the existing responsibilities of His Majesty's Representatives in the Middle East, or their official relationships with their respective departments at home. The same will apply in the Far East. The successful establishment of this machinery depends largely on your handling of it in these early critical days.

4. With your knowledge of the various public departments and of Cabinet procedure, it should be possible for you to exercise a powerful, immediately concerting influence upon Far Eastern affairs. Telegraph to me at once your concrete proposals and the form in which you would like your appointment and its scope to be defined and published. All good luck and kindest regards. We must fight this thing out everywhere to the end.

Duff Cooper addressed himself to these new duties with vigour and clarity of thought, but the arrangements we made at Washington with the United States for a Supreme Commander in the Far East to my regret made his office redundant, and a little more than a fortnight later I instructed him to return home. He was unlucky not to be allowed to go down fighting.

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We were not told for some time any details of what had happened at Pearl Harbour, but the story has now been exhaustively recorded.

Until early in 1941 the Japanese naval plan for war against the United States was for their main fleet to give battle in the waters near the Philippines when the Americans, as might be expected, fought their way across the Pacific to relieve their garrison in this outpost. The idea of a surprise attack on Pearl Harbour originated in the brain of Admiral Yamamoto, the Japanese Commander-in-Chief. Preparation for this treacherous blow before any declaration of war went forward with the utmost secrecy, and by November 22 the striking force of six carriers, with a supporting force of battleships and cruisers, was concentrated in an unfrequented anchorage in the Kurile Islands, north of Japan proper. Already the date of the attack had been fixed for Sunday, December 7, and on November 26 (East longitude date) the force sailed under the command of Admiral Nagumo. Keeping far to the northward of Hawaii, amidst the fog and gales of these northern latitudes, Nagumo approached his goal undetected. Before sunrise on the fateful day the attack was launched from a position about two hundred and seventy-five miles to the north of Pearl Harbour. Three hundred and sixty aircraft took part, comprising bombers of all types, escorted by fighters. At 7.55 A.M. the first bomb fell. Ninety-four ships of the United States Navy were present in the harbour. Among them the eight battleships of the Pacific Fleet were the prime targets. The carriers, with strong cruiser forces, were fortunately absent on missions elsewhere.

The story of this attack has often been vividly related. It is sufficient here to state the salient facts and to note the ruthless efficiency of the Japanese airmen. By 8.25 A.M. the first waves of torpedo and dive-bombers had struck their blow. By 10 A.M. the battle was over and the enemy withdrew. Behind them lay a shattered fleet hidden in a pall of fire and smoke, and the vengeance of the United States. The battleship *Arizona* had blown up, the *Oklahoma* had capsised, the *West Virginia* and *California* had sunk at their moorings, and every other battle-

ship, except the *Pennsylvania,* which was in dry dock, had been heavily damaged. Over two thousand Americans had lost their lives, and nearly two thousand others were wounded. The mastery of the Pacific had passed into Japanese hands, and the strategic balance of the world was for the time being fundamentally changed.

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Our American Allies had yet another set of misfortunes.

In the Philippines, where General MacArthur commanded, a warning indicating a grave turn in diplomatic relations had been received on November 20. Admiral Hart, commanding the modest United States Asiatic Fleet, had already been in consultation with the adjacent British and Dutch naval authorities, and, in accordance with his war plan, had begun to disperse his forces to the southward, where he intended to assemble a striking force in Dutch waters in conjunction with his prospective allies. He had at his disposal only one heavy and two light cruisers, besides a dozen old destroyers and various auxiliary vessels. His strength lay almost entirely in his submarines, of which he had twenty-eight. At 3 A.M. on December 8 Admiral Hart intercepted a message giving the staggering news of the attack on Pearl Harbour. He at once warned all concerned that hostilities had begun, without waiting for confirmation from Washington. At dawn the Japanese dive-bombers struck, and throughout the ensuing days the air attacks continued on an ever-increasing scale. On the 10th the naval base at Cavite was completely destroyed by fire, and on the same day the Japanese made their first landing in the north of Luzon. Disasters mounted swiftly. Most of the American air forces were destroyed in battle or on the ground, and by December 20 the remnants had been withdrawn to Port Darwin in Australia. Admiral Hart's ships had begun their southward dispersal some days before, and only the submarines remained to dispute the sea with the enemy. On December 21 the main Japanese invasion force landed in Lingayen Gulf, threatening Manila itself, and thereafter the

march of events was not unlike that which was already in progress in Malaya; but the defence was more prolonged.

Thus the long-nurtured plans of Japan exploded in a blaze of triumph. But this was not the end.

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The dispatch of the Japanese Ambassador to Berlin tells of his visit to Ribbentrop.

The day after Pearl Harbour at one o'clock I called on Foreign Minister Ribbentrop and told him our wish was to have Germany and Italy issue formal declarations of war on America at once. Ribbentrop replied that Hitler was then in the midst of a conference at General Headquarters [in East Prussia], discussing how the formalities of declaring war could be carried out so as to make a good impression on the German people, and that he would transmit your wish to him at once and do whatever he was able to have it carried out properly.

Both Hitler and his Staff were astonished. Jodl tells at his trial how Hitler "came in the middle of the night to my chart room in order to transmit this news to Field-Marshal Keitel and myself. He was completely surprised." On the morning of December 8 however he gave the German Navy orders to attack American ships wherever found. This was three days before the official declaration of war by Germany on the United States.

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I convened a meeting, mostly Admiralty, in the Cabinet War Room at ten o'clock on the night of the 9th to review the naval position. We were about a dozen. We tried to measure the consequences of this fundamental change in our war position against Japan. We had lost the command of every ocean except the Atlantic. Australia and New Zealand and all the vital islands in their sphere were open to attack. We had only one key weapon in our hands. The *Prince of Wales* and the *Repulse* had arrived at Singapore. They had been sent to these waters to exercise that kind of vague menace which capital ships of the highest quality whose whereabouts is unknown can

impose upon all hostile naval calculations. How should we use them now? Obviously they must go to sea and vanish among the innumerable islands. There was general agreement on that.

I thought myself they should go across the Pacific to join what was left of the American Fleet. It would be a proud gesture at this moment, and would knit the English-speaking world together. We had already cordially agreed to the American Navy Department withdrawing their capital ships from the Atlantic. Thus in a few months there might be a fleet in being on the west coast of America capable of fighting a decisive sea battle if need be. The existence of such a fleet and of such a fact would be the best possible shield to our brothers in Australasia. We were all much attracted by this line of thought. But as the hour was late we decided to sleep on it, and settle the next morning what to do with the *Prince of Wales* and the *Repulse.*

Within a couple of hours they were at the bottom of the sea.

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The tragedy of these ships, in which Chance played so fatal a part, must now be told.

The *Prince of Wales* and *Repulse* had reached Singapore on December 2. On December 5 Admiral Tom Phillips arrived in Manila by air to discuss possible joint action with General MacArthur and Admiral Hart. Admiral Hart agreed that four American destroyers should join Phillips's flag. Both Admirals felt that neither Singapore nor Manila could at the moment be a suitable base for an Allied Fleet. Next day news came that a large Japanese seaborne expedition had entered the Gulf of Siam. It was clear that decisive events were at hand. Phillips got back to Singapore on the morning of the 7th. Soon after midnight on the 8th it was reported that a landing was actually in progress at Kota Bharu, and later that other landings were being made near Singora and also at Patani. A major invasion of Malaya had begun.

Admiral Phillips judged it his duty to strike at the enemy

while they were disembarking. At a meeting of his senior officers all agreed that it was impossible for the Navy to stand out of the battle at this critical stage. He reported his intentions to the Admiralty. He requested the Singapore Air Command to move fighters to our northern airfields, and requested the utmost help from our meagre air force — namely, reconnaissance a hundred miles north of his squadron on December 9, reconnaissance off Singora from daylight on December 10, and fighter protection over Singora on the morning of December 10. This last all-important aid could not be given, first, because of the expected attack on Singapore, and secondly, because the northern airfields were already untenable. The Admiral had sailed at 5.35 P.M. on the 8th with the *Prince of Wales* and *Repulse* and the destroyers *Electra, Express, Vampire,* and *Tenedos* when news of the landing reached him. It added the warning that large Japanese bomber forces were based in Southern Indo-China. As the frequent rain squalls and low clouds were unfavourable for air action, Phillips resolved to press on. On the evening of the 9th the weather cleared, and he soon had reason to believe that he was being shadowed by enemy aircraft. The hope of surprise was gone, and heavy air attacks must be expected the next morning near Singora. At this Admiral Phillips reluctantly abandoned his daring enterprise, and after dark turned homeward. He had certainly done his best, and all might have yet been well. About midnight however by a hard mischance another enemy landing was reported at Kuantan, more than a hundred and fifty miles south of Kota Bharu. Admiral Phillips thought it unlikely that his force, last sighted by the enemy on a northerly course, would be expected so far south by daylight on the 10th. After all, he might achieve surprise. He accepted the risk and turned his ships towards Kuantan.

Japanese records make no claim to have sighted the British squadron from the air on the 9th, but a submarine reported them steering north at 2 P.M. The Japanese 22d Air Flotilla, based near Saigon, was loading bombs for an attack on Singapore. They immediately exchanged bombs for torpedoes and

decided to make a night attack on the British ships. They found nothing, and returned to their base by midnight. Before dawn on the 10th another Japanese submarine reported that the British were steering south, and at 6 A.M. a searching force of nine Japanese aircraft set forth, followed an hour later by a powerful striking force of eighty-four bombers and torpedo bombers, organised in waves of about nine aircraft each.

The report of the landing at Kuantan proved false, but as no amending message had been sent from Singapore the Admiral remained expectant, until soon after daylight the destroyer *Express* reached the harbour and found no sign of the enemy. Before resuming their southerly course the squadron spent some time in searching for a tug and other small craft which had been sighted earlier. But now the crisis came and fortune was hard. The Japanese air fleet had ranged as far south as Singapore without sighting anything. It was returning home on a northerly course, which by chance led them straight to their quarry.

At 10.20 A.M. a shadowing aircraft was sighted by the *Prince of Wales,* and soon after 11 A.M. the first wave of bombers appeared. The enemy attacked in successive waves. In the first the *Repulse* received one hit from a bomb which caused a fire, but this was soon under control and the ship's speed was not impaired. In the second the *Prince of Wales* was struck simultaneously by what seemed to be two torpedoes close together, which caused very severe damage and flooding. Both port propellers were put out of action, and the ship was never again under complete control. The *Repulse* was not hit in this attack. A few minutes later another wave closed in on the *Repulse,* and again she escaped damage. The ships by now had become somewhat separated, and Captain Tennant, having made an emergency signal to Singapore, "Enemy aircraft bombing," turned the *Repulse* towards the Admiral.

At 12.22 P.M. another attack proved fatal to both capital ships. After successfully avoiding a number of torpedoes the *Repulse* was struck amidships. Soon afterwards, in yet another attack, a torpedo wrecked her steering-gear, and then in quick

succession three more torpedoes found their mark. Captain Tennant realised that his ship was doomed. He promptly ordered all hands on deck, and there is no doubt that this timely action saved many lives. At 12.33 P.M. the *Repulse* turned over and sank. The *Prince of Wales* had received two more torpedo hits at about 12.23 P.M., and another shortly afterwards. Her speed was reduced to eight knots, and she too was soon in a sinking condition. After another bombing attack, which scored one more hit, she capsized and sank at 1.20 P.M. The destroyers rescued two thousand officers and men out of nearly three thousand. The Commander-in-Chief, Admiral Sir Tom Phillips, and his Flag-Captain, John Leach, were drowned.

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In reply to certain questions of the Chiefs of Staff about why no fighter aircraft were sent from Singapore to aid the squadron, it was confirmed that Admiral Phillips did not signal his change of plan on the 9th, as he was keeping wireless silence. His position on the morning of the 10th was not therefore known in Singapore till Captain Tennant's emergency signal was received at noon. Fighters were then sent at once. They arrived only in time to witness the sinking of the *Prince of Wales*.

In judging the actions of Admiral Phillips during these calamitous days it should be emphasised that there were sound reasons for his belief that his intended attack at Kuantan would be outside the effective range of enemy shore-based torpedo bombers, which were his chief anxiety, and that he would only have to deal with hastily organised strikes by ordinary long-range bombers during his retirement. The distance from the Saigon airfields to Kuantan was four hundred miles, and at this date no attacks by torpedo bombers had been attempted at anything approaching this range. The efficiency of the Japanese in air warfare was at this time greatly underestimated both by ourselves and by the Americans.

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I was opening my boxes on the 10th when the telephone at my bedside rang. It was the First Sea Lord. His voice sounded odd. He gave a sort of cough and gulp, and at first I could not hear quite clearly. "Prime Minister, I have to report to you that the *Prince of Wales* and the *Repulse* have both been sunk by the Japanese — we think by aircraft. Tom Phillips is drowned." "Are you sure it's true?" "There is no doubt at all." So I put the telephone down. I was thankful to be alone. In all the war I never received a more direct shock. The reader of these pages will realise how many efforts, hopes, and plans foundered with these two ships. As I turned over and twisted in bed the full horror of the news sank in upon me. There were no British or American capital ships in the Indian Ocean or the Pacific except the American survivors of Pearl Harbour, who were hastening back to California. Over all this vast expanse of waters Japan was supreme, and we everywhere weak and naked.

I went down to the House of Commons as soon as they met at eleven that morning to tell them myself what had happened.

Mr. Churchill's Speech to the House of Commons, December 10, 1941

I have bad news for the House which I think I should pass on to them at the earliest moment. A report has been received from Singapore that H.M.S. *Prince of Wales* and H.M.S. *Repulse* have been sunk while carrying out operations against the Japanese in their attack on Malaya. No details are yet available except those contained in the Japanese official communiqué, which claims that both ships were sunk by air attack.

I may add that at the next sitting of the House I shall take occasion to make a short statement on the general war situation, which has from many points of view, both favourable and adverse, undergone important changes in the last few days.

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All plans were now being made in secret for my starting for the United States on the 14th. The intervening ninety-six hours were crowded. On the 12th I had to make a full state-

ment to the House upon the new situation. There was much anxiety and not a little discontent with the long-drawn battle in Libya, which evidently hung in the balance. I did not at all conceal the prospect that very severe punishment awaited us at the hands of Japan. On the other hand, the Russian victories had revealed the fatal error of Hitler's Eastern campaign, and winter was still to assert its power. The U-boat war was at the moment under control, and our losses greatly reduced. Finally, four-fifths of the world were now fighting on our side. Ultimate victory was certain. In this sense I spoke. I used the coolest form of factual narration, avoiding all promises of early success. I ended thus:

Naturally, I should not be prepared to discuss the resulting situation in the Far East and in the Pacific or the measures which must be taken to restore it. It may well be that we shall have to suffer considerable punishment, but we shall defend ourselves everywhere with the utmost vigour in close co-operation with the United States and the Netherlands. The naval power of Great Britain and the United States was very greatly superior – and is still largely superior – to the combined forces of the three Axis Powers. But no one must underrate the gravity of the loss which has been inflicted in Malaya and Hawaii, or the power of the new antagonist who has fallen upon us, or the length of time it will take to create, marshal, and mount the great force in the Far East which will be necessary to achieve absolute victory.

We have a very hard period to go through, and a new surge of impulse will be required, and will be forthcoming, from everybody. We must, as I have said, faithfully keep our engagements to Russia in supplies, and at the same time we must expect, at any rate for the next few months, that the volume of American supplies reaching Britain and the degree of help given by the United States Navy will be reduced. The gap must be filled, and only our own efforts will fill it. I cannot doubt however, now that the hundred and thirty million people in the United States have bound themselves to this war, that once they have settled down to it and have bent themselves to it – as they will – as their main purpose in life, then the flow of munitions and aid of every kind will vastly exceed anything that could have been expected on the peace-time basis that

has ruled up to the present. Not only the British Empire now but the United States are fighting for life; Russia is fighting for life, and China is fighting for life. Behind these four great combatant communities are ranged all the spirit and hopes of all the conquered countries in Europe, prostrate under the cruel domination of the foe. I said the other day that four-fifths of the human race were on our side. It may well be an understatement. Just these gangs and cliques of wicked men and their military or party organisations have been able to bring these hideous evils upon mankind. It would indeed bring shame upon our generation if we did not teach them a lesson which will not be forgotten in the records of a thousand years.

The House was very silent, and seemed to hold its judgment in suspense. I did not seek or expect more.

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During the night of December 7/8 Mr. Eden had sailed from Scapa Flow on his journey to Moscow while the news of Pearl Harbour was actually breaking upon us. There would have been time to turn him back, but I considered his mission was all the more important in consequence of the new explosion. The relations between Russia and Japan and the inevitable reshuffling of all American supplies of munitions both to Russia and Britain raised large issues, which were also delicate. The Cabinet took this view strongly. Eden continued his voyage, and I kept him well informed. There was plenty to tell.

Prime Minister to Mr. Eden (at sea) 10 Dec. 41

Since you left much has happened. United States have sustained a major disaster at Hawaii, and have now only two battleships effective in Pacific against ten Japanese. They are recalling all their battleships from the Atlantic. Secondly, according to American sources, we are going to be heavily attacked in Malaya and throughout Far East by Japanese forces enjoying command of the sea. Thirdly, it seems to me certain that Italy and Germany will declare war on United States. Fourthly, magnificent Russian successes at Leningrad, on whole Moscow front, at Kursk and in South;

German armies largely on defensive or in retreat, under terrible winter conditions and ever-strengthening Russian counter-attacks. Fifthly, Auchinleck reports tide turned in Libya, but much heavy fighting lies ahead on this our second front. Sixthly, urgent necessity to reinforce Malaya with aircraft from Middle East.

2. In view of above you should not offer ten squadrons at present time. Everything is in flux with United States supplies, and I cannot tell where we are till I get there.

3. Hope you are better. We are having a jolly [*sic*] time here. Will start for Washington Thursday.

And further, as I embarked:

Prime Minister to Mr. Eden (at sea) 12 Dec. 41

The loss of the *Prince of Wales* and *Repulse,* together with United States losses at Pearl Harbour, gives Japanese full battle-fleet command of Pacific. They can attack with any force overseas at any point. Happily area is so vast that the use of their power can only be partial and limited. We think they will go for Philippines, Singapore, and the Burma Road. It will be many months before effective superiority can be regained through completion of British and American new battleships. The United States, under shock of Pacific disaster and war declarations, have embargoed everything for the present. I hope to loosen this up, but in present circumstances, with a Russian victory and our new dangers, we cannot make any promises beyond our agreed quota of supplies. You should point out what a grievous drain the airplanes are to us, with all these demands for fighters in the East. On the other hand, accession of United States makes amends for all, and with time and patience will give certain victory. . . .

Am just off.